

Family Icteridae

Orioles, blackbirds, and allies

Length 6–21 in (15–53 cm)

Species 109



New World blackbirds, or troupials, range from the highly colorful orioles, blackbirds, and meadowlarks to the somber-plumaged grackles. It is perhaps surprising that this family also includes the oropendolas, which in many ways appear to be closer to crows (see p.352). All these species are found exclusively in North and South America and the Caribbean. Many live close to human settlements, some benefiting from agriculture and, like the red-winged blackbird, often becoming crop pests. Although highly adaptable,

**CRESTED OROPENDOLA**

Psarocolius decumanus is widely distributed across northern and central South America, and Trinidad and Tobago. About 18½ in (47 cm) long, it is conspicuous for its loud, rasping, gurgling call, ivory bill, blue eyes, and glossy black plumage. This bird nests in colonies.

some of the members of this family are extremely rare and local. In some species, males and females differ in size and plumage. Almost all of these birds have conical, unnotched, pointed bills, but in the oropendolas, the top ridge is expanded to form a frontal shield, or casque. This is a noisy family (although not especially musical), and

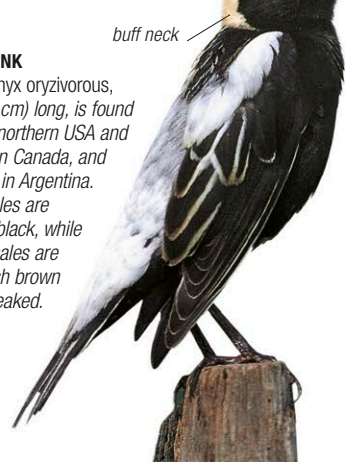
the sounds made by the oropendolas are very impressive. Cowbirds are unusual in that they parasitize the nests of other species to rear their own young. Generally, species in this family are not migratory, although the bobolink undertakes a major migration from North America to Argentina every year.

**EASTERN MEADOWLARK**

A resident of open fields and plains in south and eastern USA, *Sturnella magna* is about 9½ in (24 cm) in length and has a distinctive, black V-shaped band on its bright yellow breast. Its back is a mottled brown.

**BULLOCK'S ORIOLE**

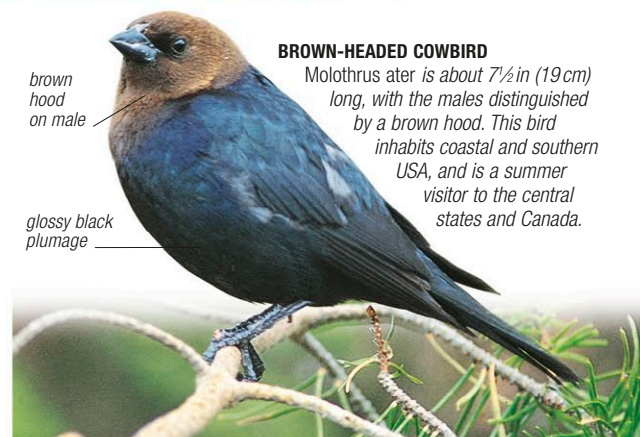
Icterus bullocki, 8½ in (21 cm) long, inhabits deciduous woodland in southwest Canada, western USA, and northern Mexico, but winters in Central America. In the Great Plains of the USA, it hybridizes with its eastern relative, the Baltimore oriole.

**BOBOLINK**

Dolichonyx oryzivorus, 7 in (18 cm) long, is found across northern USA and southern Canada, and winters in Argentina. The males are mainly black, while the females are yellowish brown and streaked.

**COMMON GRACKLE**

Found abundantly in farmland, parks, and urban areas of North America, except the western states, *Quiscalus quiscula*, 12½ in (32 cm) long, is one of the most common birds in its area. The male has a glossy purple head and neck. Both sexes have an unusual twisted tail, which is obvious in flight.

**BROWN-HEADED COWBIRD**

Molothrus ater is about 7½ in (19 cm) long, with the males distinguished by a brown hood. This bird inhabits coastal and southern USA, and is a summer visitor to the central states and Canada.

Family Prunellidae

Accentors

Length 5½–7 in (14–18 cm)

Species 13



Found in Europe, North Africa, and Asia, accentors are known for their inconspicuous behavior, often shuffling forward or hopping slowly near bushes or rocks or other cover as they scour

the ground for food—mainly insects in summer and seeds in winter. They are predominantly gray and brown, sometimes with contrasting orange or black and white markings, and their upperparts are often streaked. The adult males and females and the juveniles all look similar. Accentors have a straight, low flight, usually covering short distances. Some species have a song-flight, while others sing from a perch. In addition to simple pairs, some species of accentors—notably the dunnock—exhibit polygyny

(a male with 2 or 3 females) and polyandry (a female with 2 or 3 males). Females lay 3–6 bluish eggs that are incubated for up to 2 weeks. The young fly in another 2 weeks.

DUNNOCK

Native to Europe, *Prunella modularis* measures 5½ in (14 cm) in length, and has a whistling call. It is often found under shrubs, hunting for insects. When a dominant male mates with several females there is a subordinate male in attendance; if the subordinate succeeds in mating, he helps feed the chicks.

